STORY & DIALOGUE SPECIFICATION

Games That Feel You: Emotion-Aware Storytelling

Document details	
Module	Human–Computer Interaction
Group	CD2
Role	Design + Story
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Prepared as the Design + Story contribution to the group project.

1. Purpose of this document

This document records the story and dialogue in the five scenes supplied with the group's Godot project. It is intended to support the Design + Story contribution: documenting the narrative, player choices and story progression, and identifying story and interface elements that need group discussion.

Existing content is distinguished from proposed improvements. Recommendations in this document are not claims that a feature has already been implemented.

2. Story overview

The player takes the role of a suspect questioned by a detective about a murder. The story develops through dialogue, player choices and a suspicion score. Later, the detective breaks the fourth wall and addresses the person playing the game, introducing the idea of emotion-aware interaction.

The project's central HCI question is whether showing players what the game estimates about their emotions, and allowing them to correct or switch off that process, improves enjoyment, sense of control and trust compared with hidden emotion sensing or no emotion sensing.

Scene	Story purpose	Current story content
1 – The room is quiet	Introduce the suspect's state of mind.	Four internal-thought lines before the interrogation.
2 – The detective arrives	Introduce the detective and first player decision.	Player greets the detective or remains silent.
3 – The interrogation	Create the main branching interaction.	Six questions, three answers per question and suspicion consequences.
4 – Breaking the fourth wall	Address the real player directly.	Detective speaks to the person on the other side of the screen.
5 – The face	Set up the emotion-observation concept.	Detective comments on the player's face; webcam functionality is only a future intention in the supplied script.

3. Existing story and dialogue

3.1 Scene 1 – The room is quiet

Purpose: Establish an uneasy atmosphere through the suspect's internal thoughts.

- “The room is quiet.”
- “I should have refused. What if they find out?”
- “No, no. Everything will be fine. I need to calm down.”
- “I've already thought it all through.”

The player advances and revisits the lines using Next and Back. The scene then moves to Scene 2. There is no officer dialogue in the current script.

3.2 Scene 2 – The detective arrives

Purpose: Introduce the detective and give the player an early choice.

You: That guy looks dangerous*

Detective: So. You're the one they brought in.

Choice A – Greet him

You: Good evening.

Detective: A greeting. Warm tone, steady eyes. Rehearsed.

Detective: People who are calm don't need to prove it.

Detective: Noted: attempt to control the conversation.

Choice B – Stay silent

You: ...

Detective: No greeting. No expression. Good.

Detective: But silence is also a choice. We'll see what it hides.

Both branches lead to Scene 3. The detective interprets both responses suspiciously; this is fictional dialogue, not a reliable assessment of emotion or guilt.

3.3 Scene 3 – The interrogation

Purpose: Present six questions and let the player's answers influence the suspicion score.

Current mechanic: The suspicion score starts at 0. Each answer adds either 0 or 1. The answer options are shuffled. If the score becomes greater than 2 after a response, the caught branch begins. If all six questions are completed without exceeding 2, the released branch begins.

Question 1 – The neighbour

“Let's keep this simple.” / “Tuesday night. A neighbor says your light was on until three. Where were you?”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction
Home. I don't keep track of my lights.	0	“Home. Fine.” / “I'll write that down.”
I was asleep by eleven. My light was off.	1	“Eleven exactly. Off exactly.” / “Most people don't remember their evenings that precisely.”
Which neighbor said that?	1	“You want a name. Why?” / “Innocent people don't audit the witnesses.”

Question 2 – The kitchen

“The body was found in the kitchen.” / “On the floor, near the stove. Does that sound familiar?”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction
I wouldn't know where he was found.	0	“No. You wouldn't.”
The kitchen? That's not right.	1	“Not right?” / “Only two people know where he really was. Me, and the one who left him there.”
Was there a lot of blood?	1	“A lot. You're curious.” / “Curiosity is an emotion.”

Question 3 – The grey coat

“A witness saw a man in a grey coat leaving his building at midnight.” / “You own a grey coat.”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction
A lot of people own a grey coat.	0	“They do.” / “But not many of them were seen there.”
I own one. I wasn't wearing it that night.	1	“That night.” / “I never asked about that night. You offered it.”
Check it. You won't find anything.	1	“We will.” / “'Nothing.' You've already decided what we'll find.”

Question 4 – The victim's daughter

“He had a daughter. Eight years old.” / “She asked me today when her father is coming home. What should I tell her?”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction

I'm sorry. That's terrible.	1	“Sorry.” / “There's no room for that word here. Everyone in this building is calm. You're not.”
I have nothing to tell her.	0	“Nothing. Of course.” / “That's the answer I expected.”
Tell her he isn't coming home.	1	“Not coming home.” / “You sound very sure for someone who knows nothing.”

Question 5 – The murder method

“One blow. From behind. No struggle.” / “Is that how you would do it?”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction
From behind makes sense. He wouldn't see it coming.	1	“Wouldn't see it coming.” / “That's a very precise thought.”
No struggle? That's hard to believe.	1	“Hard to believe.” / “Why? What would you expect to see?”
I wouldn't do it at all.	0	“Everyone says that.” / “Tonight, a few of them even mean it.”

Question 6 – Someone close to the player

“Someone close to you has already talked.” / “They say you came to them afterward. Your hands weren't steady.”

Player response	Suspicion cost	Detective reaction
Bring them in. I'll say it to their face.	1	“Eager.” / “Calm people don't ask for confrontations.”
Whoever it is, they're lying.	1	“You haven't heard a name.” / “Yet you already know they're lying.”
I don't know who you mean.	0	“No. You don't.” / “We'll see.”

Scene 3 outcomes

Caught branch – triggered when suspicion becomes greater than 2:

Detective: Mm. Interesting.

Detective: We watch your face. It's all there.

This branch moves to Scene 4.

Released branch – triggered after all six questions if suspicion has not exceeded 2:

Detective: That will be all.

Detective: Thank you for your cooperation.

Detective: You may go.

The current script returns to Scene 1 after this dialogue. It does not yet display a separate ending or debrief screen.

Design note: The suspicion score is a narrative game mechanic based on assigned answer costs. It is not a measure of actual guilt. Some detective replies treat calmness, curiosity, silence or defensiveness as suspicious; these should be understood as the detective's biased interpretation, not as scientifically established indicators.

3.4 Scene 4 – Breaking the fourth wall

Purpose: Shift the detective's attention from the fictional suspect to the real player.

You: *Don't move. Don't blink.*

Detective: Good. Very still.

Detective: He controls his face well. Better than most.

Detective: But he isn't the one I'm worried about.

Detective: ...

Detective: You.

Detective: Yes, you. On the other side.

Detective: You've been very quiet. Your face is the only thing that talks.

Detective: Don't look away now.

Detective: Let's see how well you hide it.

The player advances through the dialogue. The scene then moves to Scene 5. This scene creates the narrative setup for emotion-aware interaction, but the supplied script does not activate webcam sensing.

3.5 Scene 5 – The face

Purpose: Suggest that the detective can observe the player's face.

Detective: There it is.

Detective: That face. You can stop pretending now.

Detective: ...

The supplied script describes these lines as a temporary stand-in for future webcam functionality. The scene has no configured next destination; the Next button is disabled at the final line. A complete ending is therefore not yet present in the supplied script.

4. Design issues and proposed improvements

The following items are proposals for discussion with the project manager and developers. They are not implemented features.

Area	Current position	Design proposal
Consent and privacy	No consent screen is present in the supplied scene scripts.	Explain what is sensed, why it is used, where processing occurs and whether data is stored. Offer a genuine way to continue without sensing.
Emotion monitor	No emotion-monitor panel is present in the supplied scene scripts.	In the open condition, show the system estimate clearly and allow the player to correct it or switch sensing off.
Emotion wording	Scene dialogue sometimes treats expressions as evidence.	Label outputs as estimates, not facts. Do not imply facial expression proves guilt or dishonesty.
Ending and debrief	Released route returns to Scene 1; Scene 5 has no next scene.	Agree a complete ending flow and add a debrief that explains the study and invites feedback.
Study conditions	Not implemented in these five scripts.	Keep story content comparable across button-only, hidden-sensing and open-sensing conditions.

5. HCI design rationale

HCI principle	How it should guide the design
Visibility of system status	In the open condition, make the system's estimate and sensing status visible.
User control and freedom	Let players correct an estimate, disable sensing or continue without it.
Feedback	Make clear when and how the game responds to a player choice or system estimate.
Trust and transparency	Explain that emotion estimates may be wrong and are not objective facts.
Privacy and informed consent	Explain sensing, processing, storage and opt-out choices before use.
Consistency	Keep the story and question difficulty as similar as practical across study conditions.

Important: Facial expression alone does not establish whether someone is lying or guilty. The detective can express suspicion as part of the fiction, but the design and study explanation should not endorse those statements as scientifically valid conclusions.

6. Coordination with the group

Before proposing changes to the Godot project, confirm the following with the project manager and relevant developers:

- Whether the five-scene structure and current dialogue will remain the shared story baseline.
- How the caught and released routes should end.
- Which emotion labels and outputs the technical implementation can actually support.
- Whether sensing will be live, simulated or operated using a Wizard-of-Oz approach.
- The exact consent wording, processing location, data-retention policy and opt-out behaviour.
- The visual style and layout constraints for the Godot interface.

7. Next steps for the Design + Story role

Step	Expected output
1. Review this story specification with the group and agree any changes.	Confirmed story baseline.
2. Sketch the game screen, emotion-monitor panel, consent screen and debrief screen.	Four screen designs.
3. Record the reasons for the design decisions using the HCI principles in Section 5.	Design decision log.
4. Test a paper prototype with 2–3 people and record their actual feedback.	User-testing notes and improvements.
5. Revise the documents and coordinate hand-off with the Godot developer.	Design + Story contribution ready for GitHub.

8. Use of generative AI

AI-use disclosure: Generative AI (ChatGPT) was used to assist with organising, editing and formatting this document and summarising the supplied Godot scene scripts. The existing story and implementation descriptions were based on the project files provided by the group. The student and group members must review and verify the content before submission. Responsibility for the final document, design decisions and submitted work remains with the authors.

This disclosure does not mean that AI implemented the game's code, conducted user testing or generated experimental results.

9. Overall story summary

The game follows a person who has been brought in as a suspect in a murder investigation. It begins with the suspect alone in a quiet room, thinking about the situation and trying to remain calm. A detective then arrives and begins questioning the suspect. The player chooses whether to greet the detective or remain silent, and the detective interprets either response as potentially suspicious.

The interrogation continues through six questions about the neighbour, the victim's kitchen, a grey coat, the victim's daughter, the murder method and someone close to the suspect. The player selects answers, and each answer adds either zero or one point to a suspicion score. If the score becomes greater than two, the story follows the caught branch and the detective moves on to talk about watching the suspect's face. If the player completes all six questions without exceeding the threshold, the detective ends the questioning and the current prototype returns to the opening scene.

In the later scenes, the detective breaks the fourth wall and speaks directly to the person playing the game, rather than only to the fictional suspect. The detective then comments on the player's face. This is where the story introduces its central idea: a game that may estimate a player's emotions and react to them. In the supplied prototype scripts, however, live webcam emotion detection, the emotion-monitor interface and a complete final ending are not yet implemented. These are intended areas for further development.

Story in one sentence: A murder suspect is questioned by a detective, whose growing attention to the suspect's behaviour gradually turns into direct observation of the real player, introducing the idea of emotion-aware storytelling.